interest in and understanding of statecraft, philosophy, and ethics. His experiences and exploits in later life will have added to his personal and intellectual depth, but the propensity towards such expansion will have been nurtured by the princely instruction that first honed his character.

While this early training was meant to ensure that the ruler's sons were not lacking in discipline and mental development, all princes, disciplined and undisciplined alike, were thought to pose a danger to the king.[54] In one well-known analogy, princes are like crabs—creatures known to devour their begetters. It would seem from the existence of sayings such as this that the thought of regicide diluted the filial gaze in every sovereign of the ancient world.[55] Undisciplined sons, disaffected ones, those in disfavour, and those of evil intellect are described at length, as are the ways to neutralize them or otherwise do away with them. The provisions tended to vary according to the number of sons the king had. If his only son was disaffected, he was to be put in prison; if there were many sons, the recommendation was to send the disaffected one to the frontier or some other suitably distant region where he might in time be swallowed up forever.[56]

The palpable distrust that such provisions reveals was perfectly plausible since there was no shortage of kings who had either been killed off or dethroned by ungrateful or ambitious sons. Some three centuries before Ashoka a king of Magadha, Bimbisara, in about the sixth century BCE, was murdered by his son Ajatashatru—whom we met earlier as the builder of the fortifications at Pataligrama. Bimbisara's contemporary Pasenadi, monarch of the Kosala kingdom, fared little better. His royal insignia was handed over to his son Vidudabha by one of his own ministers, the son being then installed as king while the dispossessed father was deserted by practically everyone.

In the same breath that cautions kings against their sons, the manual offers survival techniques to princes out of favour. Disguise and seeking